

MANDAR DEODHAR



BAL THACKERAY
SHIV SENA SUPREMO

UMESH GOSWAMI



VILASRAO DESHMUKH
CHIEF MINISTER

HINDUSTAN TIMES



JAYANT PATIL
STATE FINANCE MINISTER

Builders should reserve 50 per cent of houses for Marathi *manos* otherwise we will launch an agitation

Maharashtra Navnirman Sena, Raj has attained enough nuisance value for all, including the Sena and NCP. "Raj is playing populist politics by whipping up passions. And others are jumping into the ring because of their own shortcomings. They have no true development to talk about and are merely playing to the gallery," says Venkatesh Kumar, political scientist at Mumbai University.

Playing the Marathi card makes perfect electoral sense. In the state's major cities like Thane, Pune and Nagpur, Maharashtrians comprise a sizeable portion of the electorate, a vote-share no one wants to lose out on. Political observers explain that the voting patterns and issues vary from urban to rural areas. While agriculture, suicides and caste hierarchy dominate hinterland politics, jobs and invasion of migrants is a burning urban issue.

The worst hit is the Shiv Sena, an urban regional party. Putting its recent "all inclusive" strategy on the backburner, the party is rewinding to its hardliner ideology and resorting to violent tactics. Last weekend, party workers went on a rampage pulling down boards that spelt Bombay instead of the Sena favoured Mumbai. They even tried to re-christen Bombay Scottish as Mumbai Scottish, a school where Uddhav's children have studied. "Raj has struck a chord with the Marathi youth which is making the Sena insecure and forcing it to go back to its basic agenda," says Congress

The state government is committed to promoting the cause of locals, that is ensuring employment.

leader Sanjay Nirupam. In March, Bal Thackeray had demanded 50 per cent reservation in housing for Maharashtrians while Uddhav toed the sentimental line by warning migrants against "provoking the Marathis".

Doing his bit to please the Marathis, Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh recently announced that his government will ensure 80 per

COMPETITIVE SOPS

After Raj Thackeray took up the Marathi cause, other parties too went on overdrive

NCP

- Wants 80% jobs in all new industries setting up shop in the state to be reserved for Marathis.
- Insists that all MoUs with new firms must necessarily include terms on giving priority to locals in jobs.
- All establishments and institutions in the state must compulsorily display signboards in Marathi.
- Deputy CM R.R. Patil has directed police to crack down on cinema halls not screening Marathi films.

CONGRESS

- Chief Minister Deshmukh proposes to make 80% reservation for Marathis compulsory in all new industries.

SHIV SENA

- Has promised to form a union of vada pav vendors.
- Has sought 50% reservation in all new housing complexes for Marathis.

Eighty per cent jobs in companies that will now open units in Maharashtra must go to locals.

cent reservation for locals in new industries. NCP is also in no mood to be left behind. Deputy Chief Minister R.R. Patil came down heavily on cinema halls not screening Marathi films and threatened to cancel their licences if they didn't mend their ways. While addressing the legislature, state Finance Minister Jayant Patil announced that all establishments in the state must compulsorily display signboards in Marathi.

Revisiting its Marathi roots might be a feasible option for the Sena but for "national" or "secular" parties like the Congress and NCP, it's a no-win situation. Even as certain sections of the state Congress vehemently demand Raj's arrest, the fear of being labelled as anti-Marathi forced the party to passively watch the hate campaign. "The leadership feels that stern action against Raj will disturb the Congress's Marathi votebank," says a party worker. But not all agree that silence is golden in this case. A few state leaders believe that inaction could further alienate the Muslim and migrant voter from the Congress, who will feel that the party is incapable of protecting him. "Parties should offer a blueprint for the state's financial and infrastructural progress. Any kind of development should be all-inclusive," says Kumar. As the battle for grabbing Marathi attention rages on, political observers dismiss these developments as mere lip service with no concrete benefits to any citizen of the state. ■